preferred political, economic and cultural relations on a bilateral basis. Still, India's policy towards its immediate neighbourhood or periphery has been a continuation of the British policy where the interests of the Raj dictated the interests of the nearby states, not vice versa. This is the root of contemporary India's oft-expressed desire to keep outside powers from gaining influence in South Asia – a sort of Indian Monroe doctrine.



India's independence from British rule came after a protracted struggle led by the Indian elite that had been fostered over time during the colonial era. This national movement, comprising differing strands of thoughts and views, has deeply influenced contemporary India in all aspects, including foreign policy. Some leaders of the national movement sought to retain India's past while others sought to modernize India. The underlying belief of all, however, was that 'India with a more ancient civilization, longer religious and social traditions, and with its ancient literature and intellectual tradition, had much to contribute to the rest of the world'.[69] According to writers like Paul Power, the anti-colonial and anti-fascist stands of the Indian National Congress before Independence have been more influential in modern India's foreign policy than 'the amoral political advice of Kautilya's *Arthashastra* dating back from the fourth century'.[70]

The early leaders of India's national movement shaped not only the struggle for independence but also defined the contours of independent India's policies. The formation of the Indian National Congress (INC) in 1885 provided a permanent organizational structure for Indians to discuss and debate political issues, including their views on international development. Soon after formation, the Congress started making pronouncements on foreign affairs through resolutions, notwithstanding the fact that British India's international relations remained firmly in British hands. For the Congress, not only was India part of the British Empire, its